acknowledged leader in the field. And each one of these matchlocks, as Abul Fazl tells it, was tested by Akbar himself, in a long and rigorous process by which guns arrived at the emperor's chambers in the harem, marked with the source of the iron used to make them, the place of their making, the workman who made them and on what date. The guns went back and forth between the workshop and the harem many times. At the third trial, when a gun was fully made but undecorated, it was called '*sada*', plain, and sent to the harem with five bullets; of which Akbar fired four and returned the fifth, with orders for the colour of the gun's barrel and stock, gold inlay and enamel. Once ten guns were '*rangin*', coloured, this way, Akbar had their mouths and butts inlaid with gold, tried them one last time, and sent them to the armoury.

Akbar had 105 '*khasa*', select, guns for his own use – as, indeed, he had khasa weapons of all kinds, from swords to spears, daggers to bows, each with a name and a rank. His khasa guns, divided into seven groups of fifteen each, were always kept ready – Akbar used one from each group every day of the week – alongside another 101 guns kept in the harem, also rotated in this obsessive-compulsive manner.

Monserrate may not have met the bandukchis, but he did note a less lethal group of men, with far less lethal equipment, marching behind the emperor. These were surveyors, not soldiers, carrying 10-foot rods with which they measured 'each day's march'. In front of Akbar were drummers and trumpeters, though his journey was not accompanied by music. Only one drummer played at a time, writes the Father, '[sounding] his drum at short intervals, perhaps at every tenth pace, with a slow and dignified rhythm'.

On went Akbar, day by day, hunting with his beloved cheetahs, reaffirming friendships and alliances with 'petty kings' along the way. He took a leisurely three and a half months from Fatehpur to the banks of the Indus, when once he had covered a comparable distance to Ahmedabad in nine days. And yet, for all his unhurried calm, the grave and solemn cadence at which he marched, Akbar was not as unruffled by his brother's threat as he seemed.

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It was on his way north that Akbar arrested Shah Mansur, the stickler who'd wanted to tax the rioting Bengali soldiers, and had him executed on